

Golden Upgrade Rules

This may be hard to believe but it's true. The first rule of upgrading is to keep the amount of upgrading as less as possible. Let's say that you need faster performance from your PC. An increase in RAM ought to do the trick. For example, if your present memory is 64 MB, an increase to 128 MB or 256 MB should do wonders to the way your PC runs applications.

The second rule is to ensure that the stuff you buy is compatible with your present PC. Make sure you get the manuals with the components while buying them.

Third rule of upgrading is to buy stuff which you can upgrade later on. But since not all of us have the cash for a new PC every two years, we might have to spend a little extra here.

The fourth rule may sound like a contradiction to what's mentioned earlier: don't ever let the performance of a single software application determine how efficient your upgrade has been. While upgrading, look for an overall improvement in performance rather than the performance of each individual application.

And last but not the least, you should have a general idea of the latest hardware prices as well as know enough about hardware so as to not be fooled by the sugar-coated tongues of dealers and vendors. Many hardware sellers are in the habit of making you buy things that you don't really need. Being forewarned is being armed.

motherboard with a different interface. Until the day chip manufacturers decide to settle on a reasonable standard where an upgrade over a wide range of speeds is possible over time, this is going to be a difficult choice to make.

What should prove more lucrative is the varied choice available in the hardware market today. Take, for instance, the example of motherboards. A couple of years back, you could choose from only two levels—an entry-level motherboard with the most basic features to a lesser-known brand or a big brand with all the advanced features. But now, buyers have an exhaustive array to choose from and finding the right features at the price is not a problem.

The same kind of variety is available for several hardware component categories. It is more or less up to you to make use of this choice offered in the market and turbo-charge your PC.

Cram RAM

If your PC seems a bit of a laggard lately and keeps popping messages that the system is dangerously low on virtual memory, then you need to upgrade your RAM. RAM is one of the easiest and cheapest components to upgrade, and this is not just because the prices seem to be dropping every day.

Today, a 128 MB SDRAM module would cost you around Rs 850 and chances are the prices would go down even further. Installing additional RAM is as easy as this: just slide in the

RAM module from the market, check whether your motherboard has empty slots for it. In addition to this, check the maximum memory capacity module a slot can take, especially in the case of old motherboards."

It's possible to use PC133 SDRAM with older PC100/66 compatible motherboards as these memory modules are backward compatible. Installing additional RAM is cheap, easy, and does wonders to your system's performance.

More space, please

We all need space in life. Since you are upgrading, you might as well give your PC some extra storage space by putting in a new hard disk. After all, you need to put those MP3s and videos somewhere.

A hard disk upgrade would be in order if you've been getting a lot of 'out of disk space' messages. But before you step out to buy a new hard disk, Paul suggests you try out these small techniques to see if you really need it.

First, run the Disk Cleanup utility available in Windows to clean all the temporary files that clog your hard disk. The next step is to uninstall all extra programs you don't need. Then check if you're using the ancient FAT16 file system. You can do this by right-clicking on the drive and reading the information in the Properties tab. If you're using Windows 98, convert the file system into FAT32, which is more efficient in space usage by using the Drive Conversion Wizard available in Accessories>System

tools>Drive Converter. In case you use or plan to use Windows NT/ 2000/XP, you might want to switch to NTFS (NT File System). Converting FAT16 to these advanced file systems ought to give you more free disk space than plain old FAT16. This



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Paul Vincent

Software engineer, SRA Systems, Chennai

RAM module and boot your PC. The memory check at startup will show the enhanced memory details. Pratik Shah, a professional graphics designer from Mumbai who recently upgraded his PC's RAM says, "I upgraded the RAM on my PC from 128 MB to 256 MB and installed a CD-RW drive. The entire process barely took 15 to 20 minutes".

We asked Paul Vincent, a software engineer with SRA Systems, Chennai and an old hand at upgrading, about what to look out for when adding more RAM. His advice: "Before you get a

should take care of your storage needs in case you don't store heavy files like MP3s and movies.

But if that doesn't work and you still need to fit more data, then you need a new hard disk. This would be the case if your hard disk is just 2.1 to 4.3 GB in size. Remember that you can club your old and new hard disks together.

There are some terms that you need to be aware of when going in for a new hard disk drive (HDD). After size, which is the most important and measured in Gigabytes (GB), you also need